

How exercise helps

In addition to increasing your energy levels, exercise helps you maintain a positive outlook and feel confident about your changing body image. Exercise can also ease common pregnancy discomforts such as nausea, leg cramps, swollen feet, varicose veins, constipation, insomnia, and back pain. By keeping muscles strong and toned, exercise makes it easier for your body to deal with changes in posture during pregnancy. There is also evidence that increased fitness helps shorten labor and your postpartum recovery time and lessens your overall anxiety about the birth.

Food for fuel

A nutritious, balanced diet is vital in pregnancy, and even more important when you're exercising too. By drinking water and taking a snack such as nuts, fruit, or a yogurt with you when exercising, you'll avoid being tempted by sugary snacks and drinks.

EXERCISE GUIDELINES

Follow these guidelines to exercise safely in pregnancy.

Do:

- Warm up and cool down for at least 5–7 minutes before and after exercise.
- Drink enough water before, during, and after exercising.
- Wear loose, comfortable clothes that don't restrict your rib cage.
- Try to exercise regularly for about 30 minutes, 2–3 times a week.
- Adjust your expectations; pregnancy is not a time to go for personal bests.
- Build your strength gradually. Do [Kegel exercises](#). Breathe properly while exercising, especially when lifting weights.
- Protect your back when getting up from a lying position: roll onto your left side and sit up using your legs.
- Avoid exercises that feel awkward or uncomfortable or that make you feel unstable on your feet.
- Focus on posture and alignment when doing any exercise.
- Stop immediately and seek advice if you feel severe localized pain, especially in your abdomen; experience vaginal bleeding or dizziness; or if you just feel unwell.
- Eat frequent small meals and snacks to maintain energy and avoid having your blood-sugar levels fall.

Don't:

- Exercise in heat or humidity.
- Do jerky or bouncy moves and stretches or twist or rotate your abdomen.
- Lift weights that are too heavy. You should be able to lift weights easily for at least 10 repetitions.
- Do sports where you risk falling, such as skiing or horseback riding, or any high-impact movement.
- Overstretch: the pregnancy hormone relaxin can make you feel more supple than you are.
- Exhaust yourself. Decrease the intensity or duration and rest for an hour for each hour of exercise daily.